2. A Chinese Narrative of Its History

China's President Xi Jinping has spoken about the Chinese Dream. The dream is about the rejuvenation of the Chinese nation, the revival of the glory days of ancient China. It harks back to a China which had created a prosperous economy. In 1820, China accounted for 38.7 per cent of the world's GDP while India's share was 16 per cent. [1] During the more recent phase of high-level growth in China, much of Western discourse began to project the rise of China as merely revival of the dominant economic position it had enjoyed since the medieval period. This feeds into China's image of itself as always having been the Middle Kingdom – the dominant kingdom at the centre of the known world, enjoying extended pre-eminence and power in Asia. At a group study session of the Politbureau of the Central Committee of the Chinese Communist Party (CCP) held on 29 September 2020, Xi Jinping said:

> Our country has a million years of human history, 10,000 years of cultural history and more than 5,000 years of civilization history. The latest archaeological results show that China is the hometown of oriental mankind, and is tied with Africa as the first place where mankind originated; the Beijing apes invented the use of artificial fire 500,000 years ago, one of the first in the world; as early as 10,000 years ago, our ancestors planted millet and rice, and yet the origin of agriculture is tied with West Asia and North Africa as the first; China's inventions and discoveries in musical instruments, canoes, irrigation facilities, astronomy, etc. are also the first or among the earliest in the world.
>
> Our country was a world leader in the development of ancient civilizations during the Neolithic, Bronze, and Iron Ages.
>
> Chinese civilization is the only civilization in the world that has continued uninterrupted since ancient times.
>
> The ancient Chinese agricultural technology, the 'Four Great Inventions [these refer to paper, printing, gunpowder and the compass]', as well as lacquer ware, silk, porcelain, iron and steel-making technology, the county system, and the imperial examination system are distinctive and original in the history of world civilization. [2]

In this version of history, the so-called 'century of humiliation' – from roughly the Opium Wars of the mid-nineteenth century up to the 1949 liberation of China, was an aberration – and China is now poised to regain